Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Chord melody and independent-voice control

SECTION XI START | 10 MODULES | 1,056 EVENTS

Level 80 begins a new specialization block: one guitarist must carry melody, harmony, bass motion, and inner voice leading at the same time. The challenge is not simply adding more notes. Each voice must retain a distinct musical job and remain audible inside one coordinated texture.

1. Melody remains primary

The top voice must read as a melody, not as the highest accidental chord tone.

2. Bass defines direction

Bass notes establish inversion, motion, and cadence independently of the top line.

3. Inner voices explain harmony

Thirds and sevenths move smoothly even when the outer voices remain fixed.

Four-voice hierarchy

```
VOICE 1  top melody
VOICE 2  upper guide tone
VOICE 3  lower guide tone / chord body
VOICE 4  bass / root / inversion

Priority when simplification is required:
melody -> bass -> guide tones -> extensions
```

Written workload

Module	Events
A - Melody-on-top	96
B - Bass-line	96
C - Inner	96
D - Four-voice	96
E - Chord-substitution	96
F - Counterpoint	96
G - Simultaneous	128
H - Eight-bar	160
I - Sixteen-bar	128
J - Recovery,	64
TOTAL	1056

Core performance rule

Play the melody alone first. Then add the bass alone. Then add inner guide tones. If the melody becomes hidden or the pulse becomes unstable, remove the least important inner voice before slowing the tempo.

Chord melody is successful when the listener can follow the melody and the harmonic motion simultaneously.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Reference voicings and voice labels

C MAJOR / A MINOR | TOP VOICE MARKED M

KEEP MELODY, GUIDE TONES, AND BASS CONCEPTUALLY SEPARATE EVEN WHEN THEY ARE FRETTED TOGETHER

Chord	Example voicing	Bass	Inner voices	Top melody slot
Cmaj7	x 3 5 4 5 3	C	G-B	E/G
Dm7	x 5 7 5 6 5	D	A-C	F/A
G7	3 x 3 4 3 x	G	F-B	D/F
Am7	5 x 5 5 5 x	A	G-C	E/G
Fmaj7	x 8 10 9 10 8	F	A-E	C/E
E7	0 2 0 1 0 0	E	D-G#	B/E
Bm7b5	x 2 3 2 3 x	B	F-A	D/F

Voice-label drill

For every voicing, identify: bass note, chord third, chord seventh, top note, and inversion. Then remove one inner voice and confirm that the melody and bass still define the musical direction.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module A - melody-on-top voicing control, studies 1-3

3 STUDIES | 48 EVENTS

TOP VOICE MOVES; LOWER CHORD BODY REMAINS AS STABLE AS PRACTICAL

Cmaj7 - melody E-F-G-E

```
Melody: E-F-G-E
High-e/B route: x-5-5-3
Pattern: chord - melody - chord - melody
```

top line ascends then resolves

Pass 1: melody only. Pass 2: sustain bass + one guide tone. Pass 3: full voicing. Pass 4: remove one inner voice without changing melody timing.

Dm7 - melody F-G-A-F

```
Melody: F-G-A-F
High-e/B route: 6-8-10-6
Pattern: chord - melody - chord - melody
```

keep D bass stable

Pass 1: melody only. Pass 2: sustain bass + one guide tone. Pass 3: full voicing. Pass 4: remove one inner voice without changing melody timing.

G7 - melody B-C-D-B

```
Melody: B-C-D-B
High-e/B route: 12-13-15-12
Pattern: chord - melody - chord - melody
```

hear 3-11-5-3

Pass 1: melody only. Pass 2: sustain bass + one guide tone. Pass 3: full voicing. Pass 4: remove one inner voice without changing melody timing.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module A - melody-on-top voicing control, studies 4-6

3 STUDIES | 48 EVENTS

TOP VOICE MOVES; LOWER CHORD BODY REMAINS AS STABLE AS PRACTICAL

Am7 - melody C-D-E-C

```
Melody: C-D-E-C
High-e/B route: 13-15-17-13
Pattern: chord - melody - chord - melody
```

minor-third identity

Pass 1: melody only. Pass 2: sustain bass + one guide tone. Pass 3: full voicing. Pass 4: remove one inner voice without changing melody timing.

Fmaj7 - melody A-B-C-A

```
Melody: A-B-C-A
High-e/B route: 10-12-13-10
Pattern: chord - melody - chord - melody
```

3-#11?-5-3; treat B as passing color

Pass 1: melody only. Pass 2: sustain bass + one guide tone. Pass 3: full voicing. Pass 4: remove one inner voice without changing melody timing.

Cmaj7 - melody G-A-B-G

```
Melody: G-A-B-G
High-e/B route: 8-10-12-8
Pattern: chord - melody - chord - melody
```

5-6-7-5

Pass 1: melody only. Pass 2: sustain bass + one guide tone. Pass 3: full voicing. Pass 4: remove one inner voice without changing melody timing.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module B - bass-line independence, studies 1-3

3 STUDIES | 48 EVENTS

BASS CHANGES BELOW A HELD OR REPEATED TOP NOTE

Cmaj7

```
Bass: C-B-A-G
Harmony: Cmaj7 -> Cmaj7/B -> Am7 -> G7
Top voice: sustain or repeat E/G as assigned
```

Play bass alone first. Then sustain the top note. Add only enough inner harmony to make the chord quality clear.

Do not let the melody jump merely because the bass moved to a new inversion.

Am7

```
Bass: A-G-F-E
Harmony: Am7 -> G7 -> Fmaj7 -> E7
Top voice: sustain or repeat E/G as assigned
```

Play bass alone first. Then sustain the top note. Add only enough inner harmony to make the chord quality clear.

Do not let the melody jump merely because the bass moved to a new inversion.

Dm7

```
Bass: D-C-B-A
Harmony: Dm7 -> Cmaj7 -> Bm7b5 -> Am7
Top voice: sustain or repeat E/G as assigned
```

Play bass alone first. Then sustain the top note. Add only enough inner harmony to make the chord quality clear.

Do not let the melody jump merely because the bass moved to a new inversion.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module B - bass-line independence, studies 4-6

3 STUDIES | 48 EVENTS

BASS CHANGES BELOW A HELD OR REPEATED TOP NOTE

G7

```
Bass: G-F-E-D
Harmony: G7 -> Fmaj7 -> Em7 -> Dm7
Top voice: sustain or repeat E/G as assigned
```

Play bass alone first. Then sustain the top note. Add only enough inner harmony to make the chord quality clear.

Do not let the melody jump merely because the bass moved to a new inversion.

C major walkup

```
Bass: C-D-E-F
Harmony: Cmaj7 -> Dm7 -> Em7 -> Fmaj7
Top voice: sustain or repeat E/G as assigned
```

Play bass alone first. Then sustain the top note. Add only enough inner harmony to make the chord quality clear.

Do not let the melody jump merely because the bass moved to a new inversion.

A minor walkup

```
Bass: A-B-C-D
Harmony: Am7 -> Bm7b5 -> Cmaj7 -> Dm7
Top voice: sustain or repeat E/G as assigned
```

Play bass alone first. Then sustain the top note. Add only enough inner harmony to make the chord quality clear.

Do not let the melody jump merely because the bass moved to a new inversion.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module C - inner guide-tone motion, studies 1-3

3 STUDIES | 48 EVENTS

OUTER VOICES CAN REMAIN SIMPLE WHILE INNER VOICES CREATE THE HARMONIC MOTION

Cmaj7 -> Am7

```
Inner voice 1: B -> C
Inner voice 2: E -> E
Bass: C -> A
```

Pass 1: sing both guide lines. Pass 2: play them as dyads. Pass 3: add bass. Pass 4: add a repeated melody tone above.

Target minimum motion before adding extensions.

Dm7 -> G7

```
Inner voice 1: C -> B
Inner voice 2: F -> F
Bass: D -> G
```

Pass 1: sing both guide lines. Pass 2: play them as dyads. Pass 3: add bass. Pass 4: add a repeated melody tone above.

Target minimum motion before adding extensions.

G7 -> Cmaj7

```
Inner voice 1: F -> E
Inner voice 2: B -> B
Bass: G -> C
```

Pass 1: sing both guide lines. Pass 2: play them as dyads. Pass 3: add bass. Pass 4: add a repeated melody tone above.

Target minimum motion before adding extensions.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module C - inner guide-tone motion, studies 4-6

3 STUDIES | 48 EVENTS

OUTER VOICES CAN REMAIN SIMPLE WHILE INNER VOICES CREATE THE HARMONIC MOTION

Bm7b5 -> E7

```
Inner voice 1: A -> G#
Inner voice 2: D -> D
Bass: B -> E
```

Pass 1: sing both guide lines. Pass 2: play them as dyads. Pass 3: add bass. Pass 4: add a repeated melody tone above.

Target minimum motion before adding extensions.

E7 -> Am7

```
Inner voice 1: D -> C
Inner voice 2: G# -> G
Bass: E -> A
```

Pass 1: sing both guide lines. Pass 2: play them as dyads. Pass 3: add bass. Pass 4: add a repeated melody tone above.

Target minimum motion before adding extensions.

Fmaj7 -> G7

```
Inner voice 1: E -> F
Inner voice 2: A -> B
Bass: F -> G
```

Pass 1: sing both guide lines. Pass 2: play them as dyads. Pass 3: add bass. Pass 4: add a repeated melody tone above.

Target minimum motion before adding extensions.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module D - four-voice drop-and-release coordination

6 CELLS | 96 EVENTS

NOT EVERY VOICE MUST SOUND ON EVERY SUBDIVISION

Cell	Beat 1	Beat 2	Beat 3	Beat 4	Goal
1	all voices	melody	bass	melody	separate attack zones
2	bass+inner	melody	inner	melody	top-line independence
3	all voices	release	melody	bass	controlled silence
4	bass	upper dyad	bass	upper dyad	call/response texture
5	melody	inner dyad	bass	all voices	assemble from fragments
6	all voices	melody	inner	release	clean cutoff

Use Cmaj7, Am7, Dm7, G7, Fmaj7, and E7 in that order. Repeat every cell with hybrid picking, then with thumb-and-fingers only if comfortable.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module E - melody-preserving chord substitution

8 CELLS | 96 EVENTS

MELODY NOTE STAYS FIXED; HARMONY UNDER IT CHANGES

E melody

Cmaj7 -> Am7

E = 3 -> 5

D melody

G7 -> Dm7

D = 5 -> root

G melody

Cmaj7 -> Em7

G = 5 -> b3

B melody

G7 -> Em7

B = 3 -> 5

A melody

Fmaj7 -> Am7

A = 3 -> root

F melody

Dm7 -> G7

F = b3 -> b7

C melody

Am7 -> Fmaj7

C = b3 -> 5

C melody

Fmaj7 -> Dm7

C = 5 -> b7

Pass 2: invent a third chord under the same melody note. Reject it if the melody becomes an unexplained avoid tone or the bass motion loses direction.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module F - contrary motion and two-voice counterpoint

6 CELLS | 96 EVENTS

TOP AND BOTTOM VOICES MOVE INDEPENDENTLY; INNER HARMONY IS ADDED LATER

Cell	Bass	Melody	Motion
1	C-D-E-F	G-F-E-D	contrary
2	A-G-F-E	C-D-E-F	contrary
3	D-E-F-G	F-E-D-C	contrary
4	G-F-E-D	B-C-D-E	contrary
5	C-B-A-G	E-E-F-F	oblique

Three-pass build

1. Bass and melody only. 2. Add one guide tone on beats 1 and 3. 3. Add full chord color only on cadence points. Parallel fifths are not banned, but every interval must be intentional rather than a by-product of a grip.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module G - simultaneous accompaniment and lead patterns

8 PATTERNS | 128 EVENTS

ONE HAND SHAPE SUPPORTS TWO ROLES: CHORD BODY BELOW, MELODIC ANSWER ABOVE

Bass + melody

`P - m - P - a -`

thumb/pick bass, finger melody

Inner pedal

`P m a m`

hold guide tone, move top

Shell + melody

`P m a m | P m a m`

shell sustains under line

Broken chord

`P i m a`

low to high arpeggio

Chord hit + answer

`ALL - - M | - M - -`

short chord then top-line response

Reverse broken chord

`a m i P`

high to low answer

Pedal bass

`P m P a | P m P a`

repeat root under melody

Syncopated melody

`P - m a | - m - a`

melody avoids bass accents

Use Cmaj7-Am7-Dm7-G7. Keep the same right-hand pattern for all four chords before changing the melody.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module H - arrangement 1 - c major ballad

8 BARS | 40 EVENTS

MELODY MUST REMAIN SINGABLE WITHOUT THE CHORDS

Arrangement 1 - C major ballad

```
| Cmaj7 | Am7 | Dm7 | G7 |

Melody: E G A G | C B A G | F A G F | B A G D

Bass:   C A D G
```

Bars 1-4: play melody + bass only. Bars 5-8: repeat the same phrase with guide tones and chord color added. Preserve melody rhythm exactly.

Reduction test

Remove all inner voices. If melody + bass still communicate the form, the arrangement is structurally sound.

Expansion test

Add one extension only at cadence points: 9, 6, or 13. Reject any extension that masks the melody.

Final pass: perform once with hybrid picking and once with fingerstyle or pick-plus-middle/ring. Do not change tempo between methods.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module H - arrangement 2 - a minor

8 BARS | 40 EVENTS

MELODY MUST REMAIN SINGABLE WITHOUT THE CHORDS

Arrangement 2 - A minor

```
| Am7 | Dm7 | E7 | Am7 |

Melody: C E F E | F A G F | G# B D C | C B A E

Bass:   A D E A
```

Bars 1-4: play melody + bass only. Bars 5-8: repeat the same phrase with guide tones and chord color added. Preserve melody rhythm exactly.

Reduction test

Remove all inner voices. If melody + bass still communicate the form, the arrangement is structurally sound.

Expansion test

Add one extension only at cadence points: 9, 6, or 13. Reject any extension that masks the melody.

Final pass: perform once with hybrid picking and once with fingerstyle or pick-plus-middle/ring. Do not change tempo between methods.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module H - arrangement 3 - ii-v-i

8 BARS | 40 EVENTS

MELODY MUST REMAIN SINGABLE WITHOUT THE CHORDS

Arrangement 3 - ii-V-I

```
| Dm7 | G7 | Cmaj7 | Cmaj7 |

Melody: F A C A | B D F D | E G B G | E D C G

Bass:   D G C C
```

Bars 1-4: play melody + bass only. Bars 5-8: repeat the same phrase with guide tones and chord color added. Preserve melody rhythm exactly.

Reduction test

Remove all inner voices. If melody + bass still communicate the form, the arrangement is structurally sound.

Expansion test

Add one extension only at cadence points: 9, 6, or 13. Reject any extension that masks the melody.

Final pass: perform once with hybrid picking and once with fingerstyle or pick-plus-middle/ring. Do not change tempo between methods.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module H - arrangement 4 - modulating

8 BARS | 40 EVENTS

MELODY MUST REMAIN SINGABLE WITHOUT THE CHORDS

Arrangement 4 - modulating

```
| Cmaj7 | Am7 | D7 | Gmaj7 |

Melody: E G A G | C B A E | F# A C A | B A G D

Bass:   C A D G
```

Bars 1-4: play melody + bass only. Bars 5-8: repeat the same phrase with guide tones and chord color added. Preserve melody rhythm exactly.

Reduction test

Remove all inner voices. If melody + bass still communicate the form, the arrangement is structurally sound.

Expansion test

Add one extension only at cadence points: 9, 6, or 13. Reject any extension that masks the melody.

Final pass: perform once with hybrid picking and once with fingerstyle or pick-plus-middle/ring. Do not change tempo between methods.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module I - sixteen-bar chord-melody capstone map

16 BARS | 128 EVENTS

MELODY, BASS, GUIDE TONES, AND TEXTURE MUST REMAIN LEGIBLE THROUGH THE FULL FORM

Bar	Chord	Melody target	Bass	Function
1	Cmaj7	E	C	statement
2	Am7	C	A	answer
3	Dm7	F	D	rise
4	G7	B	G	cadence
5	Cmaj7	G	C	register lift
6	A7	C#	A	secondary dominant
7	Dm7	A	D	release
8	G7	F	G	turnaround
9	Em7	G	E	contrast
10	A7	C#	A	dominant
11	Dm7	F	D	predominant
12	G7	B	G	cadence
13	Cmaj7	E	C	return
14	Fmaj7	A	F	expansion

Each bar: beat 1 bass + chord body; beat 2 melody; beat 3 inner guide tone or dyad; beat 4 melody continuation or rest. Use fewer notes if independence breaks down.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module I - capstone performance passes

5 PASSES | SAME 16-BAR FORM

ADD COMPLEXITY ONLY AFTER THE OUTER VOICES ARE INDEPENDENT

1. Melody only	Sing first, then play top line alone.
2. Bass + melody	No inner harmony. Keep both voices rhythmically independent.
3. Add guide tones	Insert thirds/sevenths on beats 1 or 3 only.
4. Full chord melody	Use complete voicings only where they do not hide melody.
5. Performance version	Choose texture, dynamics, fills, and one substitution while preserving all structural targets.

Fail condition: melody disappears, bass timing shifts to accommodate the melody, or inner voices ring across a chord where they no longer belong.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Module J - reduction, recovery, and independence repair

8 CARDS | 64 EVENTS

WHEN INDEPENDENCE FAILS, REMOVE A VOICE IN A FIXED ORDER

Melody hidden

Repair: remove extension

Then: keep melody + bass

Inner note sustains wrongly

Repair: release chord body

Then: let melody continue

Bass late

Repair: remove inner voices

Then: play bass + melody only

Right hand confused

Repair: return to bass-melody alternation

Then: rebuild pattern

Chord change noisy

Repair: use shell voicing

Then: restore full grip later

Substitution sounds wrong

Repair: restore original chord

Then: keep melody fixed

Top note missed

Repair: play melody alone next beat

Then: resume harmony after target

Form lost

Repair: roots + melody target

Then: re-enter at cadence

Recovery is complete only when the listener can again follow both melody and harmonic direction.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 80

Level 80 mastery gate and practice log

SECTION XI FOUNDATION COMPLETE

ADVANCE WHEN OUTER VOICES ARE INDEPENDENT AND INNER VOICES ARE CONTROLLED

Mastery gate

- [ ] Perform six melody-on-top studies
- [ ] Perform six bass-independence studies
- [ ] Sing and play all six guide-tone pairs
- [ ] Complete four-voice drop/release cells
- [ ] Reharmonize all eight fixed melody notes
- [ ] Perform six counterpoint cells
- [ ] Complete all eight simultaneous patterns
- [ ] Perform all four eight-bar arrangements
- [ ] Perform sixteen-bar capstone twice

Score the capstone 0-2

- [ ] Melody clarity
- [ ] Bass independence
- [ ] Guide-tone accuracy
- [ ] Chord quality
- [ ] Pulse / form
- [ ] Dynamic control
- [ ] Recovery
- [ ] Musical phrasing

Pass at 14/16 or better on two separate days, with no zero in melody clarity, bass independence,

Practice log

Date	Module	Tempo	Texture	Melody clear?	Bass secure?	Weak voice	Next target

Next level

Level 81 will extend chord melody into moving inner voices, pedal tones, walking bass, passing diminished chords, drop-2/drop-3 voicings, and longer independent-voice arrangements.